

# THE DECISION AT THE GATES

The King's Crusade — Module Eleven (Final)

## OVERVIEW

The coalition takes Caer Ysolde. The party descends into the Ysolde Archive and meets Maedoc Vale in person for the first and only time in this campaign. And then — with the wizard stopped and the capital theirs — the table makes the choice this entire crusade has been walking toward without ever being told which answer is correct: hold Elduvaine, and everything the Promise was owed, or set it down, having proven it could be taken, and go home with nothing but that proof. Both endings are written here in full. Core scenes run four and a half to five hours; this module is built to take the whole session, and should not be rushed to fit a shorter one.

## WHAT THIS MODULE WILL NOT DO

It will not tell you whether Vale is still human. It will not tell you what the deepest vaults actually contain. It will not tell you which ending is the right one. These are load-bearing silences, kept on purpose across every module that came before this one, and breaking any of them now — to make the climax feel more resolved — would cost the campaign more than it would gain. Run this module trusting the silence. It has held this long because it works.

| Scene                        | Target time | Notes                                                     |
|------------------------------|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. The Gates of Caer Ysolde  | 30–45 min   | The capital falls; brief resistance, not another siege.   |
| 2. Into the Archive          | 30–45 min   | Descent. Atmosphere over combat. See the note below.      |
| 3. Maedoc Vale               | 75–90 min   | The confrontation. Stat block below. Read before running. |
| 4. The Decision at the Gates | 45–60 min   | The table chooses. Both endings follow, written in full.  |

## WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Vale is exactly what the sourcebook has always said he is: a man who wanted to finish reading, priced the world against that want, and got the sum right by his own arithmetic. He is not surprised the coalition reached him. He is mildly, genuinely inconvenienced by it — the way a scholar is inconvenienced by a library closing before he finishes a chapter, not the way a tyrant is inconvenienced by losing a war. Play him without raising his voice, ever, in this entire module.

**DM Only:** when the party finally sees him, describe him precisely and describe nothing that settles whether he is still human. He looks like a man who has not slept properly in three years and does not appear to have noticed. His hands, when he gestures, do exactly what a person's hands do. Leave it there. If a player casts a spell or uses an ability that would definitively answer the question — true seeing, a

paladin's Divine Sense reading him as something other than a living humanoid, anything similarly conclusive — it is your table's call whether to let that mechanic resolve the ambiguity or to rule that whatever he has become resists exactly that kind of certainty. Either choice is valid; picking one is a bigger decision than this module makes for you on purpose.

Likewise, whatever the party glimpses of the vaults he has been reading toward — and they should glimpse something, briefly, on the way to him — describe it as overwhelming and specific in texture (light that behaves wrong, shelving that recedes further than the room containing it should allow, a smell like a held breath) without ever stating what any of it actually is or means. The sourcebook does not answer this question. This module should not either.

## SCENE 1: THE GATES OF CAER YSOLDE

Caer Ysolde's garrison, already thin after Vindana and the field battle, does not mount a real defense — this is not another Module Six or Module Seven, and should not be run at that length or intensity. A short, sharp engagement at the outer gate (use the Occupation Guard stat block, Module 3, four to six of them) is enough; let the capital fall quickly, because the module's actual content is what waits underneath it, not another wall to break.

*The city opens ahead of the coalition almost too easily, streets emptying rather than resisting, until it becomes clear this is not fear of the coalition — it is the particular quiet of a place whose attention has been somewhere else entirely for three years. Nobody in Caer Ysolde seems especially surprised that today is the day it ends.*

Let the party move quickly through the city toward the Archive. This scene's job is momentum, not a second siege.

## SCENE 2: INTO THE ARCHIVE

The Ysolde Archive, even three years drained, is the largest collection of magical knowledge in the world, and the party descends through galleries that were built for scholarship rather than defense — which does not make them safe, only strange.

*The stacks go down further than the building above them should allow, and further than anyone escorting the party is willing to explain. Somewhere below, faintly, is a sound like a held breath, and a light that does not come from any torch or window doing something none of the party's own light sources do.*

Run this as atmosphere and tension rather than a dungeon crawl — a handful of Tiered Skill DC checks (below) to navigate safely, and perhaps one non-lethal hazard (a ward triggered by curiosity rather than malice, a section of stacks that briefly does not behave like ordinary space) rather than a string of fights. The Archive's remaining wards are not trying to kill the party; they are simply still doing their job, and their job was never intruder defense in the ordinary sense.

## TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

| Task                                                         | Skill                                  | DC | Tier     |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----|----------|
| Navigate the Archive's stacks without becoming lost          | Investigation / Survival               | 13 | Moderate |
| Recognize a ward as passive rather than hostile              | Arcana / Investigation                 | 13 | Moderate |
| Avoid triggering a curiosity-ward while examining the stacks | Investigation / Wisdom (DM's judgment) | 13 | Moderate |
| Read Vale's intentions correctly before he speaks            | Insight                                | 16 | Hard     |

## SCENE 3: MAEDOC VALE

At the bottom of the Archive, past wards that have stopped noticing anything but the specific work they were left doing, the party finds him — surrounded by open books rather than guards, in a room that does not feel like the climax of anything until he actually looks up.

*He does not reach for a weapon. He closes the book nearest to him — carefully, with a strip of cloth marking his place — before he says anything at all. "I rather thought it would be you, eventually. I want to say I'm sorry for what this cost everyone, and I find that I mean it and it changes nothing about what I'm going to keep doing until someone makes me stop. So. I suppose that's you, now."*

### RUNNING THE SCENE

Let him talk before he fights. He will answer honest questions honestly and without defensiveness — about the wards, about the deepest vaults (without ever actually naming what is in them; he will describe his want, never his destination), about the royal house, about the coalition's Promise, which he finds mildly, academically interesting as an example of exactly the kind of arithmetic he understands very well. He does not beg, does not monologue, and does not offer a redemption the party can accept — this is not that kind of scene. When the conversation ends (the party attacks, or he simply decides the conversation is over and returns to his books in a way that forces the issue), the fight is real and dangerous.

### STAT BLOCK

#### Maedoc Vale

Medium humanoid, any alignment — SRD Archmage, renamed

**Armor Class:** 15 (mage armor)

**Hit Points:** 99 (18d8 + 18)

**Speed:** 30 ft.

| STR     | DEX     | CON     | INT     | WIS     | CHA     |
|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|---------|
| 10 (+0) | 14 (+2) | 12 (+1) | 20 (+5) | 15 (+2) | 16 (+3) |

**Saving Throws:** Int +9, Wis +6

**Skills:** Arcana +13, History +13

**Senses:** passive Perception 12

**Languages:** any six languages

**Challenge:** 12 (8,400 XP)

**Magic Resistance.** Vale has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

**Spellcasting.** Vale is an 18th-level spellcaster. His spellcasting ability is Intelligence (spell save DC 17, +9 to hit with spell attacks). He can cast disguise self and invisibility at will, and has the following wizard spells prepared — Cantrips (at will): fire bolt, light, mage hand, prestidigitation, shocking grasp. 1st level (4 slots): detect magic, identify, mage armor\*, magic missile. 2nd level (3 slots): detect thoughts, mirror image, misty step. 3rd level (3 slots): counterspell, fly, lightning bolt. 4th level (3 slots): banishment, fire shield, stoneskin\*. 5th level (3 slots): cone of cold, scrying, wall of force. 6th level (1 slot): globe of invulnerability. 7th level (1 slot): teleport. 8th level (1 slot): mind blank\*. 9th level (1 slot): time stop. Spells marked \* he casts on himself before combat, and the stat block above assumes mage armor is already up.

**A Warder's Instinct.** Vale treats every spell as a rule to be applied rather than a force to be unleashed — flavor his spellcasting as precise and procedural, closer to a lock turning than an explosion, even when the effect is devastating.

### ACTIONS

**Dagger.** Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) piercing damage. He will not reach for it while he has a slot left, which is the point of it being here.

**Fire Bolt.** Ranged Spell Attack: +9 to hit, range 120 ft., one target. Hit: 22 (4d10) fire damage. Not a separate action in the SRD entry — reproduced here because it is his default turn when he is not spending a slot, and 4d10 is the 18th-level cantrip scaling.

Vale fights to disable and delay, not to kill quickly — counterspell, banishment, and wall of force are all more in character for him than raw damage, and a DM should feel free to lean on control effects over pure lethality. He does not surrender. He also does not fight to the death in the ordinary heroic sense: at the DM's discretion, a Vale reduced to under 20 hit points may attempt to teleport away rather than be finished off, particularly if the table would prefer the ambiguity of his fate to his confirmed death — either resolution (killed outright, or escaping to an unknown end) is fully compatible with everything else this module does.

## SCENE 4: THE DECISION AT THE GATES

However Vale's confrontation ended, Elduvaine's occupation is, in every practical sense, over. The coalition holds Caer Ysolde. The royal house — however much of it the party has freed — is free to reclaim its own capital. And the Promise, made all the way back at Duncarrow, is finally payable, if the coalition chooses to collect it.

*Xavier finds the party one last time, in a city that is theirs now in whatever sense anyone can agree on. He does not tell them what to decide. He has clearly been thinking about the question as long as they have, and has not arrived anywhere he is willing to call an answer. "I made a promise to get allies to march," he says. "I never actually decided, myself, what I thought we should do once we got here. I don't know that it's mine to decide. I'm not sure it's only yours, either. But I think it has to be somebody's, today."*

Let the table talk this through as themselves, not only as their characters — this is the campaign's actual final decision, and it is deliberately not adjudicated by any NPC, any mechanic, or this module. Weigh whatever the campaign has given them to weigh: the Promise and what the coalition is owed; the royal house's own divided opinions (the Ward, the Magistrate, the Regent, if met); what Elduvaine's ordinary people — Wyn Alder, Caerwyn's baker, the resistance the Regent led — actually seem to want; and what holding a kingdom whose magic responds to intention would even mean, held by people who marched here for a share of it.

When the table decides, run the matching ending below. Do not run both. Do not hint, before this moment, which one the campaign favors — it does not favor either.

## ENDING ONE: THE CROWN HELD

The coalition claims Elduvaine. Xavier's champions stand at the center of it — this is the ending in the tradition of a war won and a promise kept, and it should be played with real, earned triumph.

*The banners go up over Caer Ysolde by evening — Harrowmark's, Oksitan's, Auberitz's, and, restored to its proper place above them, Elduvaine's own. The Standing Light does not come back all at once; that will take years, the royal house's own scholars say, now that Vale's draining has stopped. But somewhere in the city tonight, for the first time in three years, one single street lights itself without anyone striking a flame, and the crowd that gathers to watch it is not entirely sure whether they are permitted to cheer. They do anyway.*

If the party signed Doria Kell's contract in Module Ten, Norvatch is paid too, and paid first, because Norvatch's instrument was the only one drawn up by people who do this professionally. Its carriers are working the Vindana road again inside a month, buying the same kingdom the coalition just bled for, entirely lawfully, from a liberated government that inherited the signature. Nobody involved has done anything wrong and everybody involved can feel it.

The Promise is paid. The coalition's land grants are drawn up within weeks, and the Ysolde Archive opens its doors — carefully, under terms the surviving royal house insists on negotiating rather than simply granting — to scholars from every allied realm. It is not a clean ending. Whichever member of the royal house the party has come to know best has real, complicated feelings about a foreign coalition now holding a legal claim on part of their own kingdom, and says so, and is not wrong to. Elduvaine is saved, and it now belongs, in part, to people who were not born in it. Both of those things are true at once, and the campaign does not ask

you to resolve the tension between them — only to have earned the right to feel it.

Xavier is remembered as the king who answered the call and, more than that, as the Wyvernheart — the name is fully his own by the time the histories are written, whatever he privately still thinks of it. The party is remembered by whatever name the table gave them, in whatever register a Listening Water somewhere is already returning it in.

## ENDING TWO: THE CROWN SET DOWN

**DM Only:** Norvatch lands differently here, and it is worth a beat. A contract guaranteeing trading rights in a liberated Elduvaine, signed by a king who then declined to hold it, is a contract with nobody — and Doria Kell says so herself, without rancour and with genuine professional regret, because she priced it correctly against a coalition that turned out not to behave the way coalitions behave. She does not threaten anybody. She writes it off, notes it, and asks what Elduvaine intends to do about tariffs, because there is going to be a government there and it is going to need a buyer. That is the whole Norvatch thesis in one exchange: it was never the war. It was always the market.

The coalition proves the crusade could be won, and then, deliberately, does not collect on it. This ending should be played as the harder-won triumph, not the sad one — Balian gave up Jerusalem having traded it for every life inside; the Skaldic Bard's Richard never took the holy city and the song does not treat that as failure. Play this the same way.

*There is no ceremony for turning a kingdom down. Xavier simply gives the order, and the coalition — grumbling, in places relieved, in places genuinely angry — begins the work of leaving rather than the work of staying. The royal house is left exactly what it was always owed: its own capital, its own choices, and no foreign banner over any of it.*

This costs something real, and the module should let it. The Promise goes unpaid — Oksitan and Auberitz march home with nothing but the proof that Vale could be beaten, which some of their own people will not consider sufficient payment for months of war and real losses. The party may need to answer for this decision to allies who feel betrayed by it, and that reckoning is not this module's to resolve; it is the shape of whatever the table imagines happens next. What Elduvaine gets instead is what it was actually owed from the start: itself, undiminished by a debt to its own rescuers.

Whichever member of the royal house the party has come to know best has their own reaction to this, and it should not be uncomplicated gratitude — someone who wanted to hold and someone who wanted to give have both had a say in what almost happened, and not everyone in that divided house will agree the party chose correctly. Xavier's own place in this ending is quieter than in the other one; the songs about him will still be written, but they will have to reckon with a king who marched an army to the gates of a kingdom and then, deliberately, did not take it. That is a harder story to tell well, and this campaign trusts its table to have earned the right to tell it anyway.

# PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

A City That Is Not Lit opens the module and is worth five uninterrupted minutes with no dice in them. Access by Rule sits inside the Archive, is the last puzzle in the campaign, and is available on both branches.

## SET PIECE: A CITY THAT IS NOT LIT

Everyone in the coalition has heard about Caer Ysolde since childhood. Nine islands, sixty-one bridges, and a whole city built of stone that held the afternoon and gave it back from the ground up on any clear night, bright enough to read by on the bridges and dim enough to see stars through. It is the thing a Fenmarrow levyman has been walking toward for eight months.

*"You come over the last rise an hour before dawn and the valley is black. Not dark — black, the specific complete black of a landscape with nothing in it, and for about four seconds the whole column assumes there has been some mistake about the road. Then somebody finds the shape of it against the sky, and it is enormous, and it is right there, and there is not one light in it except the lamps on the walls, which are lamps, which are the ordinary kind, which are burning oil like anywhere else in the world."*

Let the column stop. Nobody orders it; it simply stops, over about a minute, all along its length. There is no speech and Xavier does not make one. Somewhere back in the line a Harrowmark sergeant says something short and obscene and it carries a very long way in the quiet.

**DM Only:** this is the payoff for eight months of march and it is worth an entire uninterrupted five minutes of table time with no dice, no initiative, and no NPC explaining what anyone should feel about it. Every scene in this campaign that described light-stone — Caerwyn's doorsteps, Vindana's inner wall, the eleven feet they lit by hand in Module Eight — was building this shot. Do not add anything to it. Describe the black valley, let them look at it, and cut.

## THE PUZZLE: ACCESS BY RULE

The deepest vaults of the Ysolde Archive are behind doors that are not locked in any sense a thief would recognise. They are governed, the way the whole Archive has been governed for four hundred and eighty years, by rule rather than by power: a reader is admitted to what their rule permits and is not admitted past it, and there is no mechanism anywhere in the building for making an exception.

This is the campaign's last puzzle and it is the same puzzle Maedoc Vale spent nineteen years failing to solve. The party will have most of the pieces by now if they have been paying attention.

- **The instrument that bound the dragon named an office, not a man.** Recovered in Module Seven. It compels obedience to the Keeper of the Ysolde Archive, whoever that is, which is how Vale did it without owning the thing.
- **The Keeper is appointed by the Sovereign.** Any Archive Clerk knows this. Ottoline Vahn can produce the statute. It has never mattered to anybody because no Sovereign has ever needed to use it.

- **Maelis Ysolde is alive, is here, and has never been deposed.** Vale kept her in her own apartments, considerably, with a skilled physician, for three years — because killing her would have raised questions about a great many instruments, his own appointment among them.
- **The reading-glass shows nothing you are not entitled to read.** So it is also a test. Hand it to somebody and you can establish, in one second and with no argument, exactly what their rule permits.

The rule permits the Keeper a great deal and the deepest vaults not at all. It permits the Sovereign the same. It has no exception, has never had one, and was written that way on purpose by people who had thought carefully about exactly this situation four hundred and eighty years before it happened.

Which means Maedoc Vale opened a kingdom, hired an army, spent a third of the Living Realm, and held the building for three years, in pursuit of a permission that does not exist and cannot be created. He is not close. He was never close. Everything he has done was to buy time to look for a door that the people who built the place made sure was not there.

**DM Only:** what is behind those doors has not been decided and this book is not going to decide it. That is deliberate and it is the single most important restraint in the whole campaign: the party can establish, completely, what the rule says and what it does not permit, and they can establish what that means about Vale, and the question of what is actually in there is left to your table because your table will answer it better than a printed page can. Describe the doors. Describe the rule. Let the players do the rest, and if they force them open anyway, decide it yourself, that night, and never tell them it was not written down.

**DM Only:** note also what this puzzle does not do. It does not tell the party whether to hold Elduvaine or turn back, it does not make either ending correct, and it is available in both.

## THE THIRD WAY IN: THE SIXTH'S CONTRACT

Caer Ysolde is held by an army of employees, and a party that captured General Voss in Module Nine, or that has stood well with the Legion since Vindana, knows the two facts that follow from that. The Sixth Free Legion is on a written contract with a stated term. That term has fourteen weeks left on it.

The Legion has never broken a contract in a hundred and forty years, which is the only reason anybody hires it, and it is not going to break this one. But the contract does not require the Sixth to die for Maedoc Vale, it does not renew itself, and it is payable in coin out of a kingdom that the party can now demonstrate is a third gone and accelerating. A professional army will do arithmetic that its employer would rather it did not.

**What this opens.** Not a betrayal and not a mutiny — nothing so dramatic, and any party that pitches it that way will be refused flatly and shown out. What it opens is a negotiated withdrawal at term, or a garrison that declines to sortie, or a gate that is held by exactly as many people as the contract specifies and not one more. The Sixth will listen to a proposal delivered in writing, by somebody with standing,

that does not ask it to be dishonourable. A Norvatch factor can draft one. So can Ottoline Vahn, and she would enjoy it.

**DM Only:** this is the campaign's reward for four modules of treating the occupation as an institution rather than a monster, and it should pay out enormously — up to and including a Caer Ysolde that changes hands with a fraction of the killing either ending would otherwise cost. It does not resolve the final choice. A party that walks the Legion out still has to decide whether to hold the place or set it down, and the decision is harder rather than easier for having been handed the city cheaply. Vale, notably, does not have a contract with anybody. He is the only one left in the building who cannot be bought out, which is worth saying out loud at the table exactly once. A party that walks away from the gates having learned this is carrying something heavier than a party that took the city, and the campaign does not have an opinion about which of them was right.

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,  
the king's own chosen kept their creed.  
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,  
and the water kept their names that day.*

## NPC PROFILES

### MAEDOC VALE

See the sourcebook for his full established character. In this module specifically: unhurried, precise, genuinely regretful about the cost without that regret changing anything about his intentions. Never raises his voice. Closes his books carefully even when the room is about to become a battlefield.

Open thread: whether he dies, escapes, or is captured is this module's to decide at the table (see Scene 3's stat block note) — a DM keeping the campaign's deliberate ambiguity about his humanity intact may prefer to leave his ultimate fate just as unresolved as that question, whatever the mechanical outcome of the fight.

## DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **The campaign's final choice.** Held or set down — this is the Branch Ledger's last and largest entry, and everything else tracked across the campaign (the road choice, Calanthe or Ashgate, every rescue, every NPC's fate) is worth revisiting here as context for how the table actually arrived at this decision.
- **Vale's fate.** Killed, escaped, or captured — record which, and whether the table wanted the ambiguity preserved or resolved.

## LOOT

- **Whatever the Archive itself now represents.** Not itemized loot — the campaign's actual final reward is the ending the table chose, and this module does not attach a treasure list to that choice on purpose.

## THE REFRAIN

This is the only place in the entire campaign where the following changes. Read it exactly as written below, once, and end the session.